

2026 AI Innovator in Education Award Nomination

Meredith Carpenter – Haywood Community College

Nominee: Meredith Carpenter

Position: Business Administration Instructor

Institution: Haywood Community College

Nominator: Dr. Tim Scapin

Date: April 15, 2026

Project Overview

Meredith Carpenter, Business Administration Instructor at Haywood Community College, has demonstrated exceptional innovation in the integration of Artificial Intelligence to improve educational outcomes for community college students. Her work focuses on helping students understand not only how to use AI tools effectively, but also how to engage with them ethically, critically, and responsibly in academic and professional settings.

Through intentional course design, AI literacy instruction, and innovative classroom activities, Meredith has created learning experiences that encourage student engagement, strengthen critical thinking skills, and improve students' ability to evaluate AI-generated content. Her instructional approach prioritizes authentic learning and prepares students to navigate an increasingly AI-driven workforce.

Meredith's work has become a model for faculty across campus, demonstrating how AI can enhance teaching and learning while maintaining academic integrity and supporting student success.

Description of AI Use

Meredith integrates AI into her business courses in ways that are purposeful, ethical, and student-centered. At the beginning of each semester, she introduces students to the responsible use of AI in academic environments. Rather than treating AI as prohibited technology, she teaches students how to use it as a support tool for brainstorming, research, revision, and problem-solving while emphasizing transparency and accountability.

One of her most impactful innovations is the creation of an AI-focused instructional video that includes embedded comprehension questions throughout the presentation. This interactive resource teaches students:

- Appropriate and ethical uses of AI in coursework
- The limitations and risks of AI-generated content
- How to critically evaluate AI responses for accuracy and bias

- The importance of maintaining academic integrity while using AI tools

The embedded assessment questions ensure students actively engage with the content rather than passively consuming information. This approach reinforces comprehension while helping students internalize responsible AI practices.

Another innovative strategy Meredith implemented is a flipped business plan assignment in her Introduction to Business course. After observing an increase in heavily AI-generated submissions, she intentionally redesigned the assignment structure. Instead of discouraging AI use outright, she presented students with an intentionally AI-generated business plan and guided them through a semester-long analysis and deconstruction of the document.

Students were tasked with identifying weaknesses, missing context, unrealistic assumptions, and areas lacking authentic insight. They then used those observations to develop their own comprehensive business plans grounded in original thinking, research, and personal creativity.

This approach transformed AI from a shortcut into a teaching tool that promoted:

- Critical analysis
- Independent thinking
- Authentic student voice
- Problem-solving skills
- Real-world evaluation of AI-generated outputs

Meredith's instructional design demonstrates a sophisticated understanding of how AI can be leveraged to deepen learning instead of replacing meaningful student engagement.

Evidence of Impact

Meredith Carpenter's AI integration efforts have positively impacted both student learning and institutional culture.

Student Learning Outcomes

Students in Meredith's courses demonstrate stronger awareness of ethical AI use and greater confidence in evaluating AI-generated content critically. Her instructional methods encourage students to move beyond passive acceptance of AI outputs and instead engage in analysis, revision, and reflective thinking.

The flipped business plan assignment, in particular, has helped students:

- Better understand the limitations of AI-generated work
- Improve analytical and revision skills
- Produce more authentic and comprehensive final projects

- Develop transferable AI literacy skills for future careers

Students learn that effective AI use requires human judgment, creativity, and accountability. These lessons prepare them not only for academic success but also for the evolving expectations of modern workplaces.

Faculty and Institutional Influence

Beyond her direct work with students, Meredith serves as a leader and example for faculty colleagues interested in integrating AI responsibly into their own teaching practices. Her work demonstrates that AI can support learning outcomes when implemented intentionally and ethically.

By modeling thoughtful AI integration, Meredith is helping foster a campus culture that prioritizes:

- Responsible innovation
- Academic integrity
- Student-centered technology use
- Workforce readiness
- Ethical digital literacy

Her efforts contribute to broader institutional conversations about how higher education can adapt to emerging technologies while maintaining educational quality and integrity.

Ethical Considerations

Ethical AI use is central to Meredith Carpenter's instructional philosophy.

Rather than avoiding discussions surrounding AI misuse, Meredith directly addresses concerns related to:

- Academic honesty
- Overreliance on AI-generated content
- Bias and inaccuracies in AI systems
- Transparency in AI-assisted work
- Responsible digital citizenship

Her classroom practices encourage students to critically evaluate AI outputs instead of accepting them at face value. Students are taught that AI tools should supplement human thinking rather than replace it.

The intentional use of an AI-generated business plan as a critique exercise exemplifies her ethical approach. By showing students the limitations and shortcomings of AI-generated work, Meredith reinforces the importance of human creativity, contextual understanding, and critical reasoning.

Her instructional methods empower students to become informed and responsible users of AI technologies in both academic and professional settings.

Scalability and Sustainability

One of the strengths of Meredith Carpenter's work is its scalability across disciplines and institutions.

Her instructional strategies can be adapted easily for use in:

- Business courses
- Humanities courses
- Technical education programs
- General education courses
- Workforce development training

The AI literacy video model with embedded formative assessments can be replicated across multiple subject areas to support ethical AI instruction institution-wide.

Similarly, the flipped assignment model—where students critique and improve AI-generated work—can be adapted for writing assignments, case studies, research projects, presentations, and technical coursework.

Because her methods rely on instructional design and critical thinking rather than expensive technology, they are accessible and sustainable for community colleges and other institutions with limited resources.

Meredith's work provides a practical framework that other educators can adopt to help students develop essential AI literacy and critical thinking skills.

Nominee Biography

Meredith Carpenter is a Business Administration Instructor at Haywood Community College in Clyde, North Carolina. She is recognized for her innovative, student-centered approach to teaching, particularly in integrating emerging technologies into business education.

Meredith has become a leader in promoting ethical and effective AI use in the classroom. Her work emphasizes academic integrity, critical thinking, and workforce readiness while helping students develop the digital literacy skills necessary for success in higher education and modern careers.

Through her thoughtful instructional design and commitment to student learning, Meredith continues to model how educators can responsibly integrate AI to improve educational outcomes.